

May 25, 2026

POLICY BRIEF

001

Strengthening Youth Participation in Politics and Governance in Kenya

Executive Summary

Youth in Governance and Global Affairs organized a roundtable discussion on 6th February 2026, pegged on strengthening youth participation in politics and governance. The event was attended by leading civil society organizations (CSOs) working at the intersection of youth and governance, researchers, university student leaders, and representatives from the National Youth Council and the Centre for Multiparty Democracy–Kenya. The roundtable was convened to formulate actionable strategies from the four key findings of a research study on political participation among university students in Kenya, conducted by YIGA from May to October 2025. As the study's respondents fell within the 18–26 age bracket, the findings are considered broadly applicable to Kenyan youth within this age group. This policy brief was developed from the roundtable and incorporates inputs from the representatives highlighted above.

Introduction

Across different periods in history, university students have been agents of change in the governance of their respective countries. Between the 1960s and 1990s, youth participation across various spheres of governance was notably at its peak, with young people heavily involved in political parties, voting, and protests, among other forms of civic engagement. In Kenya, however, this trend took a negative turn as the demographic gradually slipped into selective engagement with politics and governance, evident through declining voter turnout, reduced political party membership, and diminishing participation in protests, among other areas.

Following the protests of 24th June 2024, political engagement among young people began to take a markedly different trajectory, trending towards greater participation. Young people demonstrated a keen interest in the governance of the country, particularly on matters of economic governance. This shift presented

a research opportunity to study the perceptions, motivations, and attitudes of youth, particularly university students who have historically played a key role in advocating for governance reforms across different continents. The following are the key findings from the research study.

□ **Key Finding 1: Lack of Trust in Politicians and Political Institutions**

From the study, nearly 70% of respondents identified distrust in political leaders as a major reason for their limited engagement in formal political processes. This distrust stemmed from the notion that politicians are self-serving, corrupt and unresponsive to youth needs. When asked whether politicians care about the youth, an alarming 80% of our respondents indicated that politicians do not care about the youth.

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Besides the politicians, university students similarly express distrust for political institutions, most notably the IEBC and political parties. When engaged on their trust for the IEBC, several respondents questioned the impartiality and transparency of the institution's management of previous electoral processes, often citing past controversies surrounding election results which included the death of Chris Msando, the IEBC's IT manager who was found dead under suspicious circumstances in 2017 and the 2022 resignation of four IEBC commissioners prior to the announcing of the August 2022 general elections. Despite this, when asked about their intention to vote, 75% highlight that they intend on voting in the next general election. Furthermore, the study found that the motivation to vote among university students was largely influenced by two main factors: the excitement of being first-time voters and the desire to remove perceived corrupt leaders from office.

Similarly, political parties were viewed with suspicion among university students. From our respondents, 90% of our respondents are not registered members of any political party. Furthermore, the study reveals that most students perceive political parties as vehicles for individual politicians to ascend to power, rather than as ideologically grounded institutions representing distinct policy positions or public interests. Additionally, the study's respondents view youth inclusion in political parties as symbolic rather than intentional. Similarly, this perception has in part deterred many from associating with political parties.

- ❑ **Key Finding 2: A Small Fraction of the Demographic is Disinterested in Politics and the Governance of the Country**

From the study, 20% of our respondents indicated that they had no interest in politics and governance in the country. As a result, this has negatively impacted their levels of political awareness and participation. Disinterest in politics within these individuals has contributed to the lack of knowledge of their elected leaders, major political party manifestos, and the National Youth Council, which is their representation body. On their level of political participation, the lack of interest in politics has negatively affected their participation in public consultation processes, protests, political parties and their ability to register as voters and actually turn out to vote

- ❑ **Key Finding 3: Limited Information on Political Activities Hinders Participation in Politics and the Governance of the Country**

The study notes that most respondents agreed that they do not know where to get credible political information i.e. on public consultation processes, political party manifestos, while others reported uncertainty about how to join political parties or participate in public consultation forums such as bill reviews. This aligns with qualitative insights where most participants mentioned never having encountered public notices or updates on policy consultations. All the data points out to the fact that the low political awareness of students and political apathy is a correlate of the lack of exposure to the available, credible and organized political information.

- ❑ **Key Finding 4: Social media platforms play an increasingly significant role in shaping political awareness, disseminating information, and facilitating mobilization and civic education among university students**

From the study, a significant 83% of the students reported relying on social media as their primary source of information, highlighting its central role in shaping political

awareness and discourse. Television ranked second at 33%, while the remaining respondents cited other communication channels such as radio, newspapers, and interpersonal interactions as their main sources of information.

Beyond being an avenue for acquiring information, social media has also emerged as a powerful platform for mobilization and civic engagement. For instance, among those who took part in the anti- Finance Bill protests in Kenya, 69% of the respondents indicated that

they first received information about the demonstrations online. Furthermore, when asked about their preferred platform for civic education initiatives, 70% respondents expressed social media as their preferred avenue. Traditional channels of civic education, such as community forums, received comparatively low interest among university students, highlighting a generational shift toward digital modes of engagement.

Recommendations

The policy brief recommends the following based on the four key findings discussed;

Political Parties need to;

- Clearly align their legislations to their outlined manifestos. This will help to regain and build trust especially among the young electorate that views political parties as institutions with no ideological grounding.
- Organize forums (preferably virtual) to clearly communicate and popularize their manifestos, structures and membership pathways. This will be beneficial pre and post the campaign season.
- Clearly communicate the tangible benefits of party membership and political engagement. This will help increase party membership and engagement among the demographic.

The **Independent Electoral and Boundaries Commission (IEBC)** needs to:

- Ensure that the youth committee under the IEBC is better resourced, rebuilt and recapacitated to meet the youths' needs on civic engagement.
- Organize open house forums or co-host virtual spaces to educate citizens on electoral processes and mechanisms. This will help reduce the prevailing skepticism about the IEBC's impartiality. For instance, such sessions may cover a clear explanation of how votes are cast, transmitted, counted and the safeguards against manipulation across each stage.

Civil Society Organizations need to;

- Rally and champion joint civic education initiatives to enhance visibility and reach. For instance, civil society organizations (CSOs) can partner with media houses through corporate social responsibility (CSR) programs to support civic education efforts, including running mass voter registration campaigns advertisements, public awareness messaging and targeted informational content for voters.
- Champion for the reform of the National Youth Council Act or the National Youth Council in its entirety, to pave way for an inclusive and vibrant youth body that represents the interests

of the youth and serves as the voice of the youth. This will create a formal channel for airing grievances, possibly abating protests that result from the youth lacking representation, among others.

- Individually or jointly create spaces for dialogue between the youth and persons or institutions of interest such as select politicians, IEBC among others. CSO initiatives are more likely to receive warm reception as compared to stand alone government initiatives.
- Create social media content, organize virtual or onsite fora, among other creative avenues to sensitize the youth on the direct link between politics, governance and their everyday lives. Issues such as employment, cost of living, education and security are fundamentally political. This attempt is intended to arouse the interest of individuals who are disinterested in politics and governance of the country while sustaining the interest of those already involved.
- Collaborate on effective information dissemination strategies for key governance issues such as voter registration, awareness on sensitive parliament bills among others.

County governments need to;

Develop active and regularly updated social media platforms to share localized political and governance information, including public consultation notices and county-level policy updates.

Religious institutions (such as churches and mosques) need to:

- Refrain from giving their platforms to politicians to make inflammatory political statements.
- Encourage worshippers to engage in their civic duties including voter registration, voting, participation in public consultation fora among other civic duties.

About YIGA



YOUTH IN
GOVERNANCE
AND GLOBAL
AFFAIRS

The Youth in Governance and Global Affairs (YIGA) is a youth-led civil society organization dedicated to advancing meaningful youth engagement in democratic participation, peace and security, foreign policy, and environmental sustainability across Eastern Africa. YIGA works to empower young people to actively participate in shaping policy and public discourse through capacity-building trainings, high-level workshops, and structured dialogue platforms. Grounded in a strong research-driven approach, the organization generates knowledge, fosters critical thinking, and equips youth with the skills necessary to contribute to local, regional, and global decision-making processes.

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